the rhetorical space available to him. The message to the voting public: if Nitish professes zero tolerance for corruption, the least he could do is live up to his posturing.

Maharashtra and Bihar aren't the only states that have been the target of sustained attacks by the BJP in the past year. In what can aptly be called Operation Demolition, the BJP has unleashed multiple campaigns to discredit Opposition parties that pose a threat to its mission to win a majority of the Lok Sabha seats on its own again in 2024—it had won 282 seats in 2014 and enlarged that to 303 in 2019. (The simple majority mark is 272 seats.) Psephologist Sanjay Kumar, co-director of Lokniti at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS), believes the BJP is comfortably placed in a minimum of 200 to 225 seats. His reasoning: in 2019, the BJP won 225 seats with a margin of over 100,000 votes, with 105 of these registering a 300,000-plus margin. Sanjay points out, "In 200 seats, the BJP had won over 50 per cent votes, which makes it difficult for any Opposition combine to win these seats from them. But for Prime Minister Modi and the BJP, getting anything less than a majority on its own would be a huge setback because it would not like to be dependent on coalition partners. So, the big fight is about whether it can get those extra 80 to 100 seats to ensure a simple majority on its own."

To do this, the party is focusing on 13 Opposition-ruled states, including the big ones such as Bihar, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Telangana. Together, these 13 states account for 298 seats or 55 per cent of the total 543 Lok Sabha seats. The BJP won 119 of these seats in 2019 and it propelled the party tally to 303 seats. Overall, the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance, consisting of 20 parties, won 353 seats—a decisive majority. But with several NDA partners exiting in the following years, those numbers declined steadily till the split in the Shiv Sena last year and, more recently, in the NCP gave its tally a boost.

THE MAHA STRIKE

Maharashtra had topped the list of states that could jeopardise the BJP's quest to win a majority on its own steam. The state contributes 48 Lok Sabha seats, second only to Uttar Pradesh's 80 seats. In 2019, the BJP had allied with the undivided Shiv Sena and together they won 41 of the 48 seats. Of these, the BJP had secured 23 seats and the Shiv Sena 18. The NDA combine won 51.3 per cent of the vote with the BJP contributing 27.8 per cent of it and the Sena 23.5 per cent. The UPA or United Progressive Alliance, consisting of the Congress and the NCP, won just five seats—even with a total of 32 per cent votes (Congress 16.4 per cent, NCP 15.6 per cent).

Individual vote shares and alliance combinations are key to winnability in Maharashtra, especially in the assembly

POLL-BOUND STATES

The BJP won 65, or 79%, of the 82 Lok Sabha seats in four states where assembly polls are to be held later this year. The challenge is to maintain that lead against a rising Congress

■ Total seats ■ BJP's seat tally in 2019 (Vote share)
□ Other parties



RAJASTHAN

25 / **24** (59.1%)

THE CHALLENGE
Even as Congress is embroiled in a power tussle, BJP till now has not been able to put up a united face

BJP'S GAME PLAN
Rallies by top central leaders to highlight achievements; deny ticket to lawmakers who face anti-incumbency

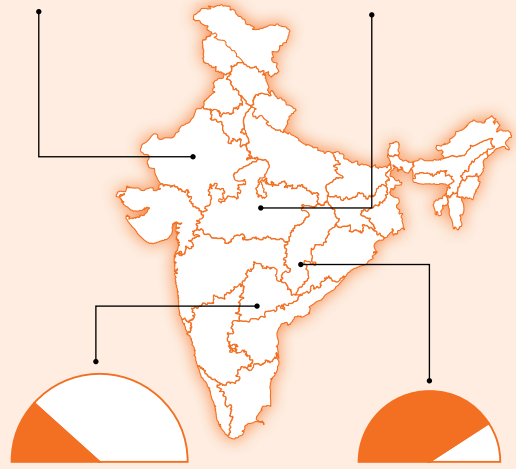


MADHYA PRADESH

29 / **28** (58.5%)

THE CHALLENGE
With Shivraj Chouhan at the helm for most of the past two decades, anti-incumbency is a big challenge. So are the internal feuds in BJP

BJP'S GAME PLAN
Field strong candidates who can impact results in nearby seats too; Union ministers to lead outreach



TELANGANA

17 / **4** (19.5%)

THE CHALLENGE
The ruling BRS stands strong; a resurgent Congress could push BJP to the third place

BJP'S GAME PLAN
Contain infighting, focus on select assembly seats like in north Telangana and around Hyderabad; join hands with BRS depending on state results

CHHATTISGARH

11 / **9** (50.7%)

THE CHALLENGE
BJP has failed to find a strong face against the sitting CM–Congress's Bhupesh Baghel

BJP'S GAME PLAN
Identify deserving former/ serving MLAs to ensure rotation of candidates for Lok Sabha polls; focus on tribal-dominated seats